MORGENTHAU AND REALISM

Political realism in IR reached its zenith and assumed a grotesque stature in the hands of Hans J. Morgenthau in his seminal work *Politics Among Nations: The Struggle for Power and Peace* (1948). His six principles or signposts are:

1. Politics, like society in general, is governed by objective laws that have their roots in human nature which is unchanging. Therefore, it is possible to develop a rational theory that reflects these objective laws.
2. The main signpost of political realism is the concept of interest defined in terms of power which infuses rational order into the subject matter of politics, and thus makes the theoretical understanding of politics possible. Morgenthau views international politics as a process in which national interests are accommodated or resolved on the basis of diplomacy of war. He upheld that "The concept of national interest presupposes neither a naturally harmonious, peaceful world nor the inevitability of war as a consequence of the pursuit by all nations of their national interests. Quite to the contrary, it assumes continuous conflict and threat of war to be minimized through the continuous adjustment of conflicting interest by diplomatic action".
3. Realism assumes that interest defined as power is an objective category which is universally valid but not with a meaning that is fixed once and for all. In a world in which sovereign states compete for power, survival constitutes the minimum goal of foreign policy and the core national interest. The protection of "their physical and cultural identity against encroachments by other nations" constitutes the vital interest which is common to all states. Therefore, the basic minimum national interest identifiable is national survival and other interests are determined by the requirements of time, place, culture, socio-economic and political condition of the states.

To support his argument, Morgenthau gives classic examples from history. One such is the policy of Great Britain in 1939–40